



PULLING BACK FROM THE BRINK

Innovative measures by the government and proper execution of NREGS have brought down suicides by farmers in Kerala

■ By **M.G. Radhakrishnan**

Life for K. Prasanna, 35, of Poothadi in Wayanad district and her two sons changed one day in August 2005. Her husband, T.D. Gopi, 40, a marginal farmer committed suicide by consuming insecticide after a local money lender seized his land for repeatedly defaulting on paying loan instalments of Rs 25,000. Prajish, her elder son who had just entered Class XI had to drop out of school and take up odd jobs to keep the kitchen fire burning.

Three years later, Prasanna has reasons to cheer again. She has got work under the National Rural

Employment Guarantee Scheme (NREGS) in Wayanad and earns Rs 125 a day. Backed by a grant from the local panchayat she is now building a new house in place of her old hutment. Prasanna attributes the change in her life to NREGS. "I worked for 85 days in the last six months and made more than Rs 10,000 which considerably added to what my son brings working as a carpenter."

A recent study shows that between 1997 and 2005, over 1.5 lakh farmers took their lives, of which nearly 11,516 were from Kerala. The spices and coffee-rich Wayanad, where 90 per cent of the population depends on agriculture for a living, was the epicenter

A NEW BEGINNING: Women workers show their NREGS identity cards in Wayanad

of the state's agrarian crisis and accounted for 90 per cent of the state's suicides in the region. A fall in crop prices and plant epidemic pushed several farmers into debt, driving them to death and destruction. The National Sample Survey in 2003 revealed that Kerala faced the highest farmer indebtedness after Punjab. The indebtedness of an average farmer family in the state at Rs 33,907 was thrice the national average of Rs 12,585. The government says Wayanad farmers have lost an estimated Rs 5,000 crore between 2001-2005 due to a crash in the prices of coffee, pepper, ginger, arecanut etc.

But the trend is reversing now. In 2007 the state reported less than 10 farmer suicides as against 131 in 2004. A series of steps, including a two-year long moratorium on farm loans since 2005 and the stoppage of recovery proceedings by banks, helped abate suicides. The government also took over the debts of the families of 412 deceased farmers and gave Rs 50,000 each as compensation. This was fol-